What does "Phenomenological" Mean?

Let's start by taking the scary-sounding word "Phenomenological" and breaking it down into bite-sized pieces so it makes sense. The word actually comes from two old Greek words put together. The first part comes from "phenomenon," which simply means "that which can be seen" or anything that is happening in front of us. The second part, "logy," is a suffix you've probably seen before in biology or psychology; it just means "to study."

So, when we put them together, "Phenomenologlcal Research" is just a fancy way of saying we are studying things that happen to people. But unlike a math test where there is one right answer, this type of research looks at social "phenomena"—events or experiences that people go through together. It is a way of asking questions about how humans live and feel.

Think of it as an inquiry method, which is a formal way of asking deep questions. We aren't looking for statistics or numbers here. Instead, we are exploring shared human experiences. We ask big questions like, "What is reality really like for this person?" and "How does this person relate to the world around them?" It is about exploring the story behind the event.

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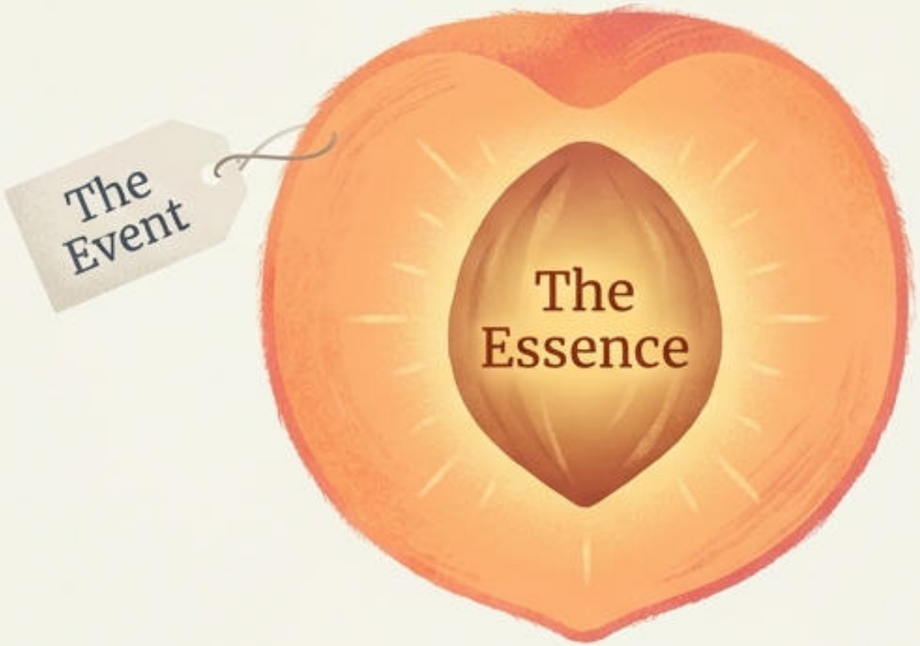

The Core Goal of Phenomenology

Every type of research has a goal. For phenomenology, the goal is to capture the "essence" of an experience. You can think of the essence as the core or the heart of what an experience is really like. It isn't enough to just say "John went to the store." We want to know what it ***felt*** like for John to go to the store, what he was thinking, and how that trip changed his day.

This method is heavily focused on the "lived experience." This means we aren't guessing what it might be like to be in a certain situation; we are talking to people who have actually lived through it. We want to describe the meaning of that experience from their point of view.

We look at two specific things: what was experienced (the actual events) and how it was experienced (the feelings, thoughts, and senses involved). By combining these two things, we can paint a full picture of reality that helps us understand what it is like to walk in someone else's shoes.

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Reality through the Participant's Eyes

In many types of science, **the researcher is the expert who judges everything.** But in phenomenological research, the roles are flipped. **Here, the only view that matters is the view of the audience—the participants who are part of the study.** They are the experts because they are the ones living the life we are studying.

We record and analyze their beliefs, their feelings, and how they perceive the world. If a participant thinks a **situation was scary, then for the purpose of our research, it *was* scary.** Their perception is the reality we are trying to capture.

This means the researcher has a very difficult job: they must keep their own opinions out of it. The researcher's personal assumptions, or what they *think* they know about the topic, must be treated as irrelevant. If the researcher lets their own judgment creep in, it ruins the picture of the participant's reality.

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Why do we use this Research?

You might wonder, why do we need a research method that focuses so much on feelings? The primary aim is to gain deep insight into how a specific group of people feels about a specific event. These stories, or “narratives,” become the data we study. They allow us to see a version of the truth that we might miss if we were just looking from the outside.

Sometimes, this research adds to what we already know, but often, it contradicts it. We might think we know how a situation feels, but talking to the people involved reveals a totally different story. It allows us to develop new theories based on actual human emotion rather than just logical guesses.

For example, imagine a study on family members waiting for a loved one undergoing major surgery. A doctor might see this as a standard medical procedure. But for the family, it is a life-changing, stressful event. By researching their experience, we can understand the "nature" of waiting—the anxiety, the hope, and the fear—from a broader family perspective, rather than just a medical one.

Phenomenology in Business

While this sounds very philosophical, it is actually used a lot in the business world, especially in branding. Companies often have a very specific idea of what their brand is. They might say, “We are a high-tech, efficient company.” But that doesn’t matter if the customers don’t feel the same way.

In business research, the audience’s perception is the only reality that counts. It matters much more than the business’s perception of itself. If a company wants to succeed, they need to know how the customer experiences their product. Do they feel happy when they use it? Do they feel frustrated?

Researchers look at these customer experiences to find the emotional connection. If they find out that customers feel “safe” using a product, the company can change their advertisements to talk more about safety. This helps the business adjust their strategy to evoke, or bring out, stronger and more positive feelings in the future.

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Characteristic 1: Audience Interpretation

Phenomenological research can look different depending on the subject, but there are four main rules, or “tenets,” that it always follows. The first and most important characteristic is a strict focus on audience interpretation.

This means we are focused on “sense-making.” We aren’t just writing down a list of events that happened. We are trying to figure out how the person *made sense* of those events. How did they interpret what was happening to them?

The focus is always on what an experience means to a strictly defined group of people. If we are studying “teachers,” we focus only on how teachers interpret a school day, not the students or the parents. We want to know the internal meaning they attach to the external events.

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Characteristic 2: Lack of Researcher Bias

The second characteristic is perhaps the hardest one to achieve: a complete lack of researcher bias. We call this the “ethics of the mind.” As human beings, we all have prejudices, assumptions, and past experiences that color how we see the world.

However, to do this research correctly, the researcher has to act like a blank slate. They must set aside all their prior prejudices and assumptions. This is often called “bracketing”—imagine putting your own thoughts in brackets [ ] and leaving them there so they don’t touch the rest of the sentence.

The researcher should focus *only* on how the audience interprets the event. If the researcher thinks an event was “fun” but the participant says it was “boring,” the researcher must accept “boring” as the truth. You cannot let your own influence change the data.

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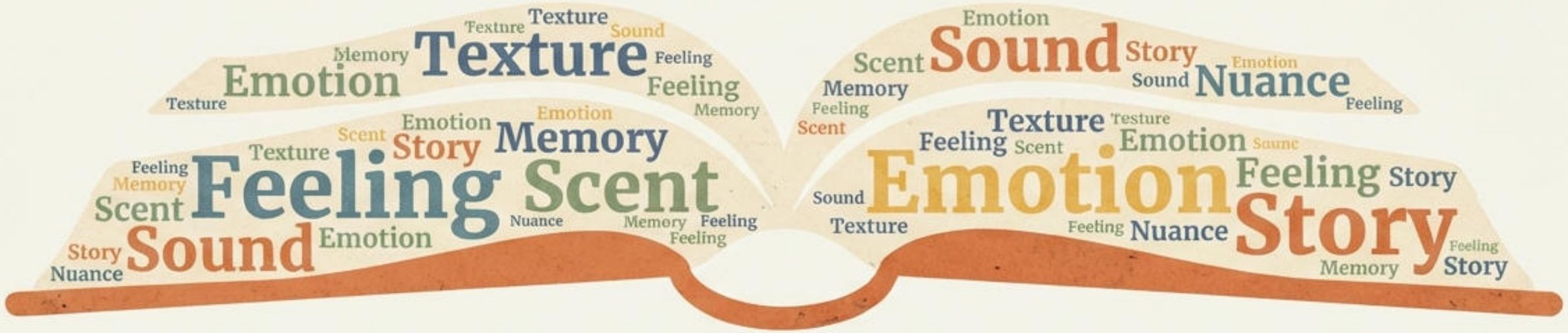
Characteristic 3: Descriptive Emphasis



The third characteristic is a descriptive emphasis. If you ever read a report from this type of research, you will notice it is very long and wordy. It doesn't rely on charts or graphs; it relies on rich, detailed language.

The goal is to describe the "lived experience" as comprehensively as possible. Comprehensively means "completely and thoroughly." We want to capture every nuance and detail. We don't just want the summary; we want the full story.

The researcher tries to describe the phenomenon through the eyes of the audience. This often involves using quotes, stories, and metaphors to make sure the reader can really feel what the participant felt. It is about painting a picture with words.

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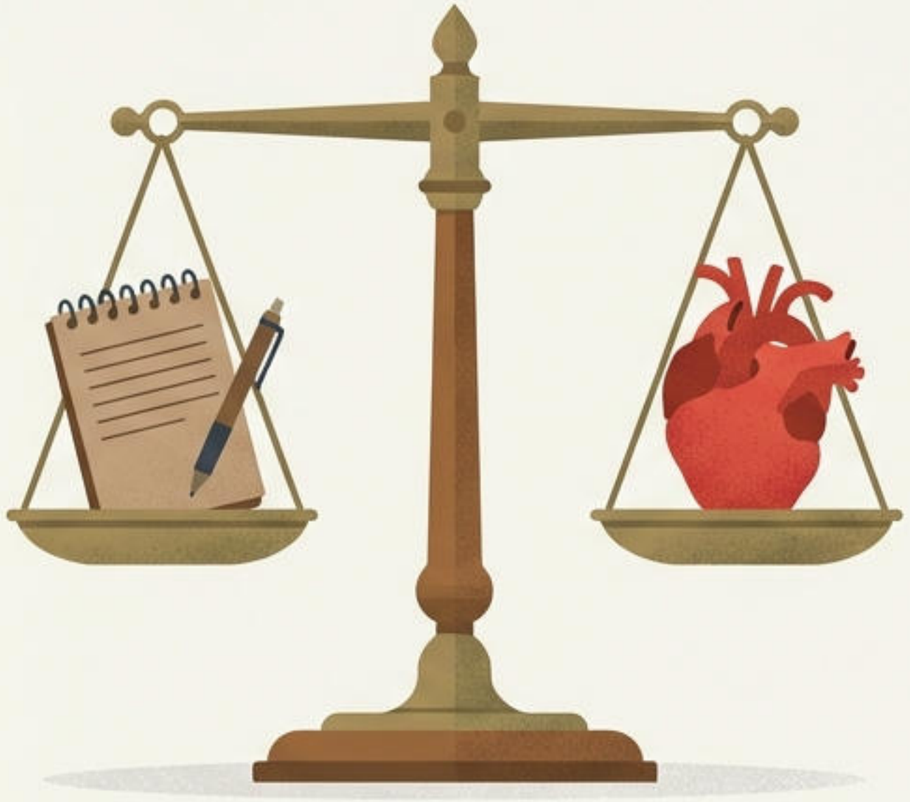
Characteristic 4: Objectivity meets Experience



The fourth characteristic is about connecting objectivity with lived experiences. This sounds like a contradiction, but it is actually a balance. Objectivity means looking at facts without letting feelings get in the way. Lived experience is all about feelings. How do we combine them?

Researchers do this by acting as careful observers. They need to describe their objective observations of how the audience acted during the event. For example, “The participant cried when they spoke about their dog.” That is an objective fact.

But they must combine this with how the audience interpreted that experience. “The participant said they cried because they felt a sense of relief, not sadness.” By combining the observed action (crying) with the internal meaning (relief), we get a true understanding of the phenomenon.

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The Three Types: Existential

Now that we know the rules, let's look at the three specific types of phenomenological research. The first type is called **Existential Phenomenology**. This is the type most commonly used in business and marketing contexts. Existential phenomenology focuses entirely on understanding the audience's experiences through their own perspective. It is about their existence in the world. It asks, "What is it like to be you in this specific moment?" For a business, this is incredibly valuable. It helps you relate to your customers. If you can understand their existence—their struggles, their joys, their daily routines—you can create products and services that fit perfectly into their lives. It bridges the gap between a company and the people it serves.

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The Three Types: Hermeneutic

The second type is **Hermeneutic Phenomenology**. This is a bit more abstract. The word “hermeneutic” comes from a Greek word meaning “to interpret.” While existential phenomenology describes experience, hermeneutic phenomenology goes a step further to *interpret* it.

This type focuses on “creating meaning” from experiences. It assumes that people are constantly interpreting their own lives. It looks at the history, the culture, and the language a person uses to explain why things happen to them.

You can use this to gain a deeper understanding of *how* your audience perceives experiences related to your business. It isn’t just about what happened; it’s about the story they tell themselves about what happened. It is a deep dive into the hidden meanings behind everyday events.

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The Three Types: Transcendental

The third type is **Transcendental Phenomenology**. This is the most scientific and academic version of the three. It is rarely used in business; it is mostly reserved for philosophy and social sciences. Transcendental phenomenology focuses on how a phenomenon appears in 'consciousness' on a broader scale. Consciousness refers to the state of being aware of things. This method tries to strip away everything that makes an experience unique to one person (like their specific culture or background) to find the universal truth that applies to everyone. It looks for the pure, 'transcendental' nature of an experience. For example, instead of asking 'How did *you* feel grief?' it asks 'What *is* grief fundamentally?' It is less about the individual and more about the concept itself.

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How is Data Collected?

Since we aren't using surveys with multiple-choice questions, how do we actually get the information? We use "Qualitative Research Techniques." Qualitative refers to quality and description, rather than quantity and numbers.

One common tool is **observation**. This involves watching participants as they experience the phenomenon in real-time. We might also use **in-depth interviews**, talking participants before, during, and after an event to see how their feelings change.

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We also use **focus groups**, where a small group of people experience something together and then discuss it. Sometimes, researchers will even **record natural conversations** between participants to hear how they talk about the topic when they think no one is listening. These methods give us the raw, unfiltered data we need.

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Analyzing Personal Texts

Another fascinating way to collect data is by analyzing personal texts. This doesn't just mean text messages; it refers to anything a participant has written or created that documents their life.

Researchers might ask participants to share their diaries, journals, or personal notes. These documents are incredibly valuable because they were written in the moment, often without thinking about a researcher reading them later. They are honest and raw.

We also look at observations and even photos. Sometimes, a participant can explain a feeling better by showing a picture than by using words. By analyzing these “rich” details, researchers can piece together the puzzle of the participant’s daily life and find the “essence” we are looking for.

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Limitations: Small Samples

No research method is perfect, and phenomenology has some significant limitations. The biggest one is sample size. Because we have to interview people for hours and analyze their diaries, we can't study thousands of people at once. These studies are typically very small—often fewer than 20 or 30 people. This results in a small data set. Because the group is so small, it is difficult to draw "complete conclusions." We can't say "Everyone in the world feels this way" just because five people in our study felt that way. This means the findings are not always "statistically significant" in the way a math-based study would be. We trade breadth (studying lots of people) for depth (studying a few people very deeply). It is a trade-off the researcher has to accept.

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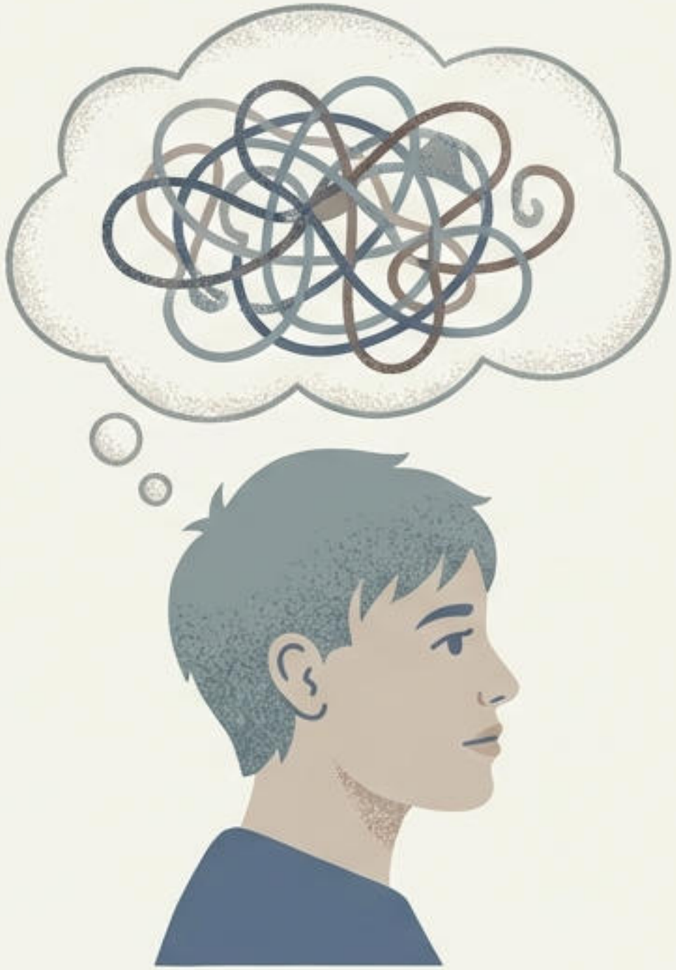
Limitations: The Human Element



Another major limitation is the human element. This entire method relies on the audience's ability to explain themselves. Its accuracy depends entirely on how well the participants can express their experiences and feelings. If a participant has trouble finding the right words, the data won't be as good.

There is also the risk of **researcher bias**. Even if a researcher tries their hardest to "bracket" their opinions and remove their bias, it is very difficult to do perfectly. Subconscious prejudices can still sneak in and contaminate the outcome.

Finally, this type of study is incredibly time-consuming. Summarizing the data is hard because there are no clear numbers. Interpreting the stories can take days or weeks, and the final conclusions usually have to include "qualifiers"—little warnings that say, "This might not apply to everyone."

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Case Study: Parents of Children with Autism

Let’s look at a real-world example to see this in action.

A researcher named Donna Marie Barrow conducted a study titled “A Phenomenological Study of the Lived Experiences of Parents of Young Children with Autism.” Autism is often diagnosed around 18 months, but help usually doesn’t start until age three or four. Barrow wanted to know what that gap felt like for parents. She didn’t just ask them questions; she used a technique called “**photo elicitation.**” She asked parents to take photos of their daily lives and use those pictures to spark conversation. This helped the parents remember specific moments and feelings that they might have otherwise forgotten. It created “rich, detailed descriptions” of their struggle to find help for their children.

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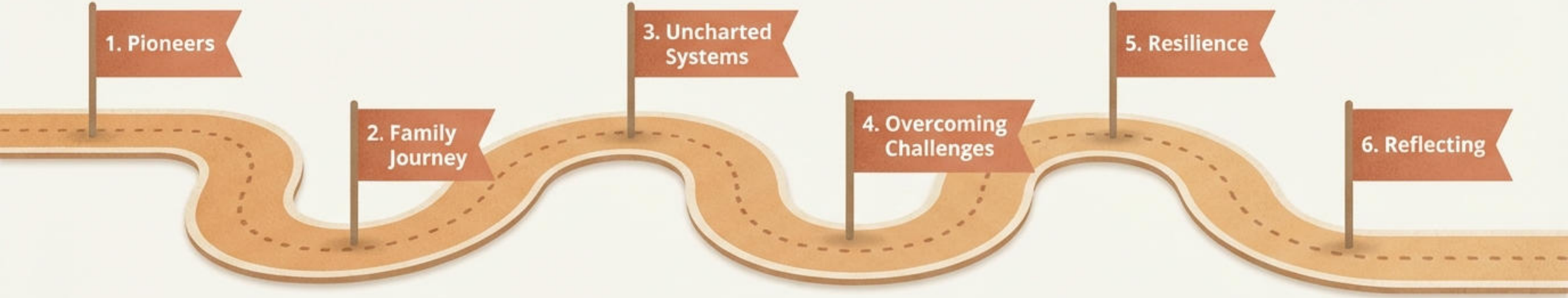
Findings from the Autism Study



When Barrow analyzed the photos and the conversations, she didn't find statistics; she found themes. She discovered six essential themes that described the parents' reality.

One theme was "**Parents as Pioneers.**" The parents felt like they were exploring new territory, forging a path for future families. Another theme was "**Navigating Uncharted Systems**," describing how lost they felt trying to deal with schools and doctors.

Other themes included "Making the journey as a family" and "Resilience, ingenuity, and hope." The most important result was that the participants felt the study gave them a "voice." It allowed their personal struggles to be seen and understood by the scientific community, validating their lived experience.

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Case Study: Emotions in Academics

Trust/Helpfulness

Isolation

Here is another example. A group of researchers wanted to study the “emotional orientation” of academics—basically, how professors feel about their jobs. They interviewed 26 volunteer academics using in-depth, face-to-face interviews.

The study found that emotions played a huge role in how these professionals worked. When they were teaching or working with others, they showed positive emotional orientations like **trust** and **helpfulness**. Their “unique professional characteristics” made them want to work collectively.

However, the study also found that when they were forced to work alone or focus on administrative tasks (“job-centering efforts”), they felt negative emotions. The research concluded that a professor’s emotions are a “reality” that shapes their professional life. If universities want happier staff, they need to structure the work so professors aren’t isolated.

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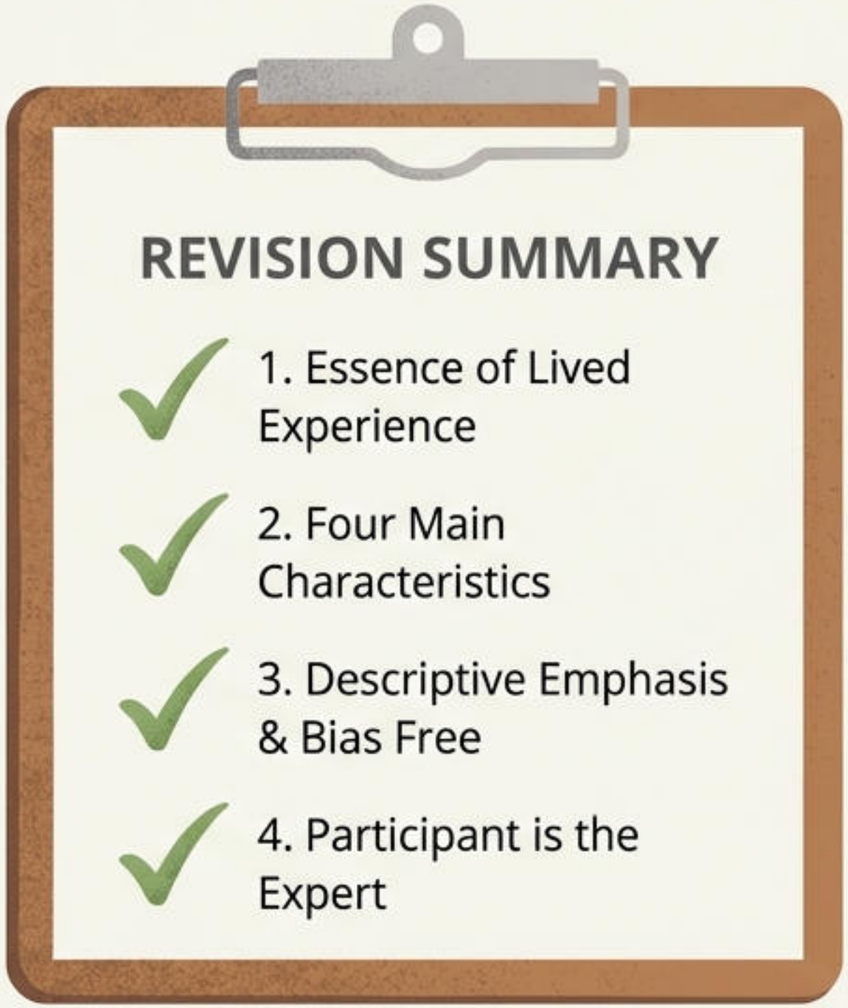
Summary for Exam Revision



We have covered a lot today! To wrap up, let's review the key points you need to remember. First, remember the word **'Essence.'** The goal of phenomenology is to describe the core, essential heart of a lived experience.

Second, remember the **Four Main Characteristics**:

1. Focus on the audience's interpretation (how they make sense of things).
2. Lack of researcher bias (bracketing your own opinions).
3. Descriptive emphasis (using rich, detailed language).
4. Connecting objectivity with the subjective lived experience.

Finally, always remember that in this method, the **participant is the expert**. We are looking at reality through *their* lens, not ours. Whether it is parents of children with autism or customers buying coffee, we listen to their stories to understand the truth of their world.

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